

Spotify releases iPad app

The new layout is much sleeker than the clunky, iTunes-inspired desktop version. A premium subscription is required to use the app, despite it being free to download



PureView 808 is coming in May

Nokia confirmed that the 41MP camera smartphone is coming in May as promised way back in February <http://dgit.in/KuRGgD>

Talking Storage

We had a free-wheeling discussion with Richard Rutledge, Western Digital, Chief Operating Officer at the WD Annual Summit in Vienna. An excerpt...

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Q Due to the Thailand floods, the prices of HDDs have gone through the roof. By when will the pricing normalise? Also, there's a fear that distributors are purposely keeping the prices higher. What do you have to say about that?

I don't think prices will ever come down to what they were. We'd developed a total supply chain in and around Thailand, based completely upon cost. We had multiple sources and multiple factories but all were in the same geographic area. There are some structural costs added to our industry that will probably never go away, but in general prices responded to the floods immediately and went up, and they've been on a decline, albeit a slow decline since. I think in India prices went up above ₹3,000 when I was there.

As for the bloated prices by the distributors, their financial results wouldn't support that.

Q WD has a plant in Malaysia, and Hitachi which you recently acquired has a presence in China. Are you planning to open plants in other areas to reduce the dependence on one single location?

We started the company in 1970 and have been in operation in Malaysia since 1972. We're the largest MNC in Malaysia and Thailand. The industry made a lot of investment in South-East Asia. So it started from Singapore, then moved north to Malaysia and then to Thailand. If you look at Thailand, there are a number of industries there such as the car industry, Nikon's camera facilities, etc. A lot of the partners who provide the components are also based in Thailand, so we have to



Richard Rutledge, COO, Western Digital

be sensitive towards Thailand. Thanks to our acquisition of Hitachi, we have some presence in the Philippines. Today we have some capacity in China, outside of Shenzhen, out of Hong Kong. Quite honestly, it's not really cost effective to have facilities outside Thailand, as all the partners who manufacture the components are located within a 25 km radius of our facility. The entire disc drive was produced inside 25 kms.

Q The Thunderbolt drives are priced very high. Who's it targeted at?

There are content creation professionals, spending their whole day developing content, developing web pages and they understand the benefit of making their lives easier. But in general, the reason Thunderbolt is being developed is because in some time, data will be transitioned from going down through wires, to going through optical cables. The idea is to move from wires and electricity to optic fibre cables and light. The technology really

works. The reason behind it is that all technologies from SATA to USB can go to a maximum of 5-6 Gbits/sec, which goes through a pair of wires. The benefit to the consumer today is that it's really fast.

Q What's Western Digital's stand on hybrid drives?

We're interested in hybrid drives. What you'll see in an Ultrabook is an SSD, typically around 24 GB along with a regular hard drive, typically 500 GB and up. What will happen is your data will be cached to your SSD. So we'll have an mSATA port based SSD along with a regular HDD. After that technology gets adopted in the mainstream, we can do a lot of interesting things, by bringing the SSD on the HDD. In such a scenario, the HDD will be off most of the time as all the data will go via the SSD.

Q Is there a reason to use SLC NAND in place of MLC NAND? Why is MLC NAND not used – it can probably give you a better capacity SSD while keeping the pricing low?

The current products that Intel have announced are all SLC-based NANDs in the hybrid drives because the computer is very data intensive. As flash tends to wear out soon, SLC is most appropriate to use today. Yes, people are working on implementing the drives with an MLC NAND to get the pricing down.

Q Could you elaborate on the personal cloud storage that WD is investing in? The WD2Go apps are free and so long as you have a WD external drive, you can access data on it using this app. Now with big players like Google coming into the picture, where do you see WD personal cloud headed?

In our components business, we have a marketing pitch called "the power of choice". Even in a 2.5-inch and 3.5-inch segment, we have varieties based on the need. We have products for laptops, desktops and enterprise products. So, in general we believe in choice. It's not clear to us whether people are comfortable putting all their data in a public cloud. A company